

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Faith and Good Deeds

Jesus did not teach that we are saved by doing good things (“works”). Instead, he taught that we need to be changed on the inside. This change (or conversion) happens when God works in us through his grace. When God changes us, we naturally begin to live differently and obey him. When someone has a real relationship with Jesus Christ, they will do good things as a result (see, for example, Matthew 7:15–20; 12:33–37; 15:15–20).

The parable of the sheep and the goats shows how faith and actions closely connect. This link between faith, actions, and God’s final approval is a common theme in Jesus’ teachings (for example, Matthew 7:13–27; 13:3–9, 18–23; 16:27). For Jesus, actions plainly show faith, which begins with repentance. Repentance is a change of heart and mind that causes a person to stop sinning and become more obedient to God (Matthew 4:17; see also 3:2, 8–10; 11:20–24; 12:38–42).

Some misunderstand what salvation by God’s grace means. This has created a false distinction between faith and works. Salvation does not come from works alone, but it also includes them (see Galatians 5:6, 21; Ephesians 2:10; 5:5; 1 John 1:5–10; Revelation 21:8). Jesus promises blessings and rewards to those who obey God’s will (Matthew 5:3–12). Therefore, righteousness is necessary for those who wish to “enter the kingdom of heaven” (5:20–48; 7:21; 22:11–14; 23:3). Faith that does not produce works is not saving faith (James 2:14–26).

The apostle James emphasizes being faithful to God and argues that doing good things shows faith (2:14–26). A relationship with God cannot rely only on believing a true statement (2:19). True faith leads to actions (1:22–25; 2:14). Faithful actions imitate God, who generously gives good gifts (1:5, 17; 4:6). Faith and good works cannot be separated. Like Abraham, good works show that a person has complete faith and is righteous before God (2:23; see Genesis 15:6).

Jesus taught and showed that faith involves doing good works (see Matthew 5:13–16). Paul also emphasized the importance of good works (Romans 2:6; Galatians 6:5–10; Ephesians 2:10; Philippians 2:12–13; 1 Thessalonians 1:3).

James’s letter emphasizes specific actions that show faith. These include:

- Caring for orphans and widows (1:27)

- Not favoring the rich (2:1–7)
- Providing food and clothing for the poor (2:15–17)
- Controlling what one says (3:1–12)
- Promoting peace (3:17–18)
- Not judging others (4:11–12)

These actions are “faith expressing itself through love” (Galatians 5:6).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 17:1; 22:1–19; Leviticus 22:31; Habakkuk 2:4; Matthew 3:2, 8–10; 4:17; 5:3–12, 20–48; 7:13–27; 10:32–33; 11:20–24; 12:33–42; 13:3–9, 18–23; 15:15–20; 16:27; 25:31–46; John 15:2; Romans 2:6; Galatians 5:6, 16–26; 6:5–10; Ephesians 2:8–10; 5:3–9; Philippians 2:12–13; Hebrews 11:1–40; James 2:14–26; 1 John 1:5–10; Revelation 21:6–8

False Prophets

The Bible describes many people who claimed to be prophets without authority and a true calling from God. They spoke as if they represented God. People often found it difficult to tell true prophets from false ones. False prophets usually told people what they wanted to hear (see, for example, 1 Kings 22:10–14; Jeremiah 28:1–4).

Due to this difficulty and the Lord’s merciful delay in judging his rebellious people, many doubted that God’s message through his true prophets would come true (see Isaiah 5:19). Others denied that anything would happen during their lifetimes. Could the often-delayed punishment wait a little longer?

Ezekiel prophesied that in the upcoming judgment on Jerusalem, God would remove false prophets. This would help people identify true prophets (Ezekiel 13:8–9). God’s judgment would happen without delay—the Lord would soon fulfill his words (13:11). Everyone would then know which words were truly from God and which words false prophets imagined.

Jesus warned that false prophets would appear in the future (Matthew 24:11–28). His early followers encountered many false prophets (see, for example, Acts 13:6–12; 2 Peter 2:1–3). Christians can often identify false prophets by their incorrect teachings about Christ. These teachings show that God’s Spirit does not guide them (1 John 4:1–3).

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 13:1–5; 18:22; 1 Kings 22:8–28; Jeremiah 6:13–15; 14:13–16; 20:1–6; 28:1–17; 29:21–32; 50:6; Ezekiel 13:1–23; 22:28; Micah 3:5; 2 Corinthians 11:13–15; 2 Timothy 4:3–4; 2 Peter 2:1–3

Family, Community, and Sexual Sin

In Israel, the family was the foundation for the unity of the community. Each of the twelve tribes was a mixed group of families and clans. Together, these tribes made up the entire nation of Israel.

While this unified identity might weaken with distance from a person's immediate family, this family concept was present throughout Israelite society. A relative was often called a brother. This showed how close they felt to each other. Extending this family model, the term often translated as "brother" could also mean a fellow Israelite (see Deuteronomy 1:16, "a man and his brother"; Deuteronomy 3:18, "your brothers, the Israelites").

In ancient Israel, the community was like a large family. So, the home's integrity was important. Crimes like incest (sexual relationships between close family members) and adultery (when a married person has a sexual relationship with someone who is not their spouse) had harsh punishments because they harmed family relationships. Incest damaged trust between family members, destroyed the safe environment that a home should provide, and broke the special bonds that family members should share. Adultery harmed families by people giving loyalty to someone other than their spouse. These threats to family unity weakened the clan and tribe, and finally, the nation's unity (see Leviticus 18:6–23).

Sexual sins, even ones to which both people agree, are not without victims. They can eventually harm the community. Old Testament laws emphasize these crimes, and the New Testament also warns against sexual immorality (see especially 1 Corinthians 5:1–2; 6:13–20; 7:2; Galatians 5:19–21; Ephesians 5:3; Jude 1:7; Revelation 2:14–16, 20).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 19:30–38; 49:3–4; Leviticus 18:6–30; 20:14, 21; 2 Samuel 13:1–39; Matthew 14:3–5; 1 Corinthians 5:1–2; 6:13–20; 7:2; Galatians 5:19–21; Ephesians 5:3; Jude 1:7; Revelation 2:14–16, 20

The Family Redeemer

The idea of the family redeemer was established in the law of Moses. The story of Ruth shows us an example of this idea. In that book, this term has a specific legal meaning. In other places, the Hebrew term *go'el* translates as "next of kin" (Numbers 27:11; 35:19, 24).

According to the Moses' law, family redeemers had three main duties in Israel:

1. Leviticus 25:23–34 explains that if an Israelite became very poor and had to sell his land, a family member should pay off the debt to keep the land in the family. If no relative could buy the land and the seller could not buy it back, the land would still return to the seller or his heirs in the Jubilee year (fiftieth). Two examples of family redeemers buying land for their relatives are Boaz and Jeremiah (Ruth 4:1–12; Jeremiah 32:6–15).
2. Similarly, if an Israelite became very poor and had to sell himself into debt-slavery, a family redeemer had an obligation to release him from service to a non-relative (Leviticus 25:35–55). The poor Israelite would repay his debt by working for his relative. He would probably treat him better than a stranger would.
3. The family redeemer was responsible for seeking justice if someone killed an Israelite, as described in Numbers 35:9–34.

The idea of the family redeemer shows us that God owns everything. He tells us to love our neighbors as ourselves (Leviticus 19:18; Matthew 22:39–40). The New Testament describes Jesus as the perfect family redeemer. He frees us from the slavery of sin and death, which we chose for ourselves (Matthew 20:28; Romans 3:24–25; Ephesians 1:7; Titus 2:14; Revelation 5:9; compare Exodus 6:6; 15:13; Psalm 130:8; Isaiah 44:22; 59:20; 63:9; Jeremiah 31:11).

Like the Old Testament family redeemer, such as Boaz, and following our great redeemer's example, we must show love and kindness to others (Leviticus 19:11–18; Matthew 5:43–48; 19:19; 22:37–40; Romans 13:8–10; Galatians 5:14; James 2:8–9).

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 25:23–55; Numbers 35:9–34; Ruth 2:20; 3:9, 12; 4:1–10; Isaiah 59:20; Jeremiah 32:6–15; Matthew 20:28; Romans 3:24–25; Ephesians 1:7; Titus 2:14; Revelation 5:9

Famine

Famine happened early in the lives of the patriarchs Abraham and Isaac (Genesis 12:10; 26:1). When the patriarch Jacob's family experienced famine, God had already placed his son Joseph in Egypt to help God's people through the crisis (41:56–42:5; 45:5, 7). This famine was very severe. But famines were common in the ancient world (see Ruth 1:1; 2 Samuel 21:1; 1 Kings 18:1–2; Haggai 1:1–11; Acts 11:28).

Famine was a terrible disaster in farming societies. Drought, crop failure, or siege could cause it (2 Kings 25:1–30). Famine often came with disease or war, af-

fecting many levels of society (Jeremiah 14:12). This included animals (Joel 1:20). People relied on rain, so some people stored food to prepare for famine (Genesis 41:33–36; 47:23–24; compare 1 Chronicles 26:15; 2 Chronicles 31:11; Nehemiah 10:37–39).

When there was not enough food, many bad things happened (Genesis 12:10; 26:1; 2 Kings 6:24–29; Nehemiah 5:1–3; Jeremiah 19:9; Lamentations 2:20–21; 4:8–10).

- Food became very expensive.
- People stole from each other.
- The poor were treated unfairly.
- Farms could not grow crops.
- People had to leave their homes to find food.
- In the worst cases, people even ate human flesh to survive.

Sometimes, people considered famine as a punishment from God against the Israelites (Leviticus 26:14–20; Deuteronomy 11:16–17; 28:33; Jeremiah 29:17–18). Therefore, being faithful to God was very important (Psalm 33:18–19; 37:19). God’s blessings on the nation included protection from famine (Ezekiel 34:29; 36:29–30).

Jesus experienced a famine similar to Israel’s during his time in the wilderness. He chose not to make bread just for himself (Matthew 4:1–4; see also Deuteronomy 8:3). His success against the devil’s temptation showed that lack of food and hunger can build humility and trust in God’s care. Jesus fed five thousand people to show them he is “the bread of life,” God’s “true bread from heaven” (John 6:32–35).

Yet, the crowds followed him more for the food than for who he is (John 6:26–27). While not ignoring physical food, Jesus emphasized spiritual hunger and thirst (Luke 6:21; John 4:34). Eating serves as both a setting and a symbol for fellowship (Genesis 43:34; Luke 22:15–16; Revelation 19:9). In heaven, hunger will no longer exist (Revelation 7:16).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:10; 26:1; 41:33–36, 56–57; 45:6–7; Leviticus 26:19–20; Deuteronomy 8:3; 11:16–17; Ruth 1:1; 2 Samuel 21:1; 1 Kings 18:1–2; 2 Kings 8:1–2; Jeremiah 14:11–16; Ezekiel 34:29–31; 36:28–32; Joel 1:1–20; Amos 8:11–14; Haggai 1:1–11; Luke 6:21; John 6:32–35; Acts 11:28–30; Revelation 7:16

Fear of the Lord

As Moses gives his final instructions to the people of Israel before his death, he repeatedly urges them to “fear the LORD” (see, for example, Deuteronomy 6:1–

13; 10:12–21; 31:9–13). Joshua gives the same advice near the end of his life (Joshua 24:14). Fear means respect, a feeling of wonder at something great, and sometimes being very afraid. Fearing the Lord involves always being aware of his authority and power. For the Israelites, fearing the Lord meant recognizing that their success depended entirely on God.

The main theme of Proverbs is summarized in the words: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge” (Proverbs 1:7). This fear makes people humble and less prideful (3:7; 15:33). With this attitude, people will obey God more than rely on their own judgment. Fear of the Lord acknowledges God’s central role in the world’s order. God is the creator and master of everything.

This is why Psalm 14:1 calls those who reject God “fools.” Those who fear the Lord gain wisdom because they understand that everything is under God’s rule and serves him. This is more than just an attitude. It is a way of living that respects God’s power and authority and our ultimate responsibility to him.

Wisdom is linked to a good relationship with God. Both need choices that match God’s character (see Job 28:28; Proverbs 14:2; Ecclesiastes 12:13). Do you want wisdom? Then you must be in a relationship with the one who has all wisdom (see 1 Corinthians 1:1–2:16; Colossians 2:3).

Passages for Further Study

Job 28:28; Psalms 14:1; 111:10; Proverbs 1:7; 3:7; 8:13; 9:10; 10:27; 14:2, 26–27; 15:16, 33; 19:23; 22:4; Ecclesiastes 12:13; Isaiah 11:1–2; 33:6

Fearing People

God promised to be with his people when they encountered opposition (see, for example, Deuteronomy 20:1–4; Joshua 1:9). As long as they remained committed to him, they had no reason to fear others. Israel’s history showed this truth (see Exodus 14:10–31; Joshua 10:9–14). Yet, for those who seek peace and security elsewhere, God can become “a rock of offense” instead of a “sanctuary” (Isaiah 8:14).

During King Ahaz’s rule in Judah, he became very afraid when he heard that Syria and Israel had joined to fight against him (Isaiah 7:2). The Lord urged him to have faith, as faith was necessary for the Lord’s protection (7:9). Yet, Ahaz chose not to trust the Lord. Instead, he sought help from the Assyrians. This decision caused the Lord to become “a trap and a snare” for him and for all of Israel and Judah (8:11–15).

The prophet Isaiah's message intended to show the difference between faith and fear. King Ahaz is an example of fear. King Hezekiah is an imperfect example of faith (Isaiah 37). Isaiah himself is a better example of faith (chapter 8). Finally, God's "Servant" is the ideal example of faith (42:1-7; 50:4-7).

Jesus told his followers not to fear people who threaten them, even those who want to kill them (Matthew 10:26-31). God knows every sparrow and the number of hairs on a person's head. God will be with those who trust in him. Christians have shown this trust throughout history by not fearing what others can do to them, even dying for their faith (see Acts 6:8-7:60).

People who do not fully commit to God will fear others. But those who trust in the Lord can overcome this fear. They understand that human enemies are temporary, while God's power lasts forever.

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 14:1-12; 21:34-35; Joshua 1:9; 2 Kings 16:5-18; 2 Chronicles 28:16-23; Psalm 23:4; Proverbs 29:25; Isaiah 7:1-25; 41:10; 51:7-8, 12-13; 54:4; 57:11; Jeremiah 10:5; 30:10; 46:27-28

Fishing in Galilee

Jesus' knowledge of fishing is obvious in the four Gospels. He used fishing in his stories to teach people (Matthew 7:10; 13:47-51). When Jesus called his first followers, he told them, "I will make you fishers of men," meaning they would help bring people to God (Matthew 4:19). In John 21, after Jesus rose from the dead, he even used fishing to show himself to his followers.

In ancient Galilee, people who fished for a living only used nets. They used three types of nets:

1. The drag net was one of the oldest types of nets. It was like a wall, with weights at the bottom and cork floats at the top. People first pulled it along the coast. Then, a boat dragged the lead rope across the sea and pulled it back to shore.

The drag net caught many fish, including some that Jewish law did not allow for eating. People sorted the fish. They kept the good ones and removed the bad ones. Jesus used the drag net as a symbol for the day of judgment (Matthew 13:47-51).

1. The cast net was circular and measured fifteen to twenty feet across. They attached lead weights to its edges. A lone fisherman tossed it into the sea. It landed, sank, and caught unsuspecting fish. The fisherman then dove into the water and either

pulled the fish out one by one or gathered the net and lifted it into the boat. Simon and Andrew used cast nets when Jesus called them (Matthew 4:18-20; Mark 1:16-18).

2. The trammel net is the only type still used today. It is made of three layers. The two outer nets are the same and have wide openings. The inner net is finely meshed and loose, moving easily in and out of the outer nets. Fishermen spread the net in the water in a long line, usually at night, and hold it while others scare fish toward it.

Fish enter the first outer net easily, push against the fine mesh inner net, and then carry the fine net into the second outer net, becoming hopelessly entangled. The fishermen then haul the net ashore. They untangle the net and sort the fish, and repair the many breaks in the net. When Jesus called James and John to follow him, they were repairing their trammel nets (Matthew 4:18-22; Mark 1:19-20).

When Jesus told Simon to lower his net again after fishing all night, Simon caught a miraculous number of fish (Luke 5:1-11). A similar thing happened in John 21:1-11 when Simon Peter came back from an unsuccessful night of fishing. Jesus instructed him to throw out his net again. Peter probably used a cast net, which then filled with so many fish that it was hard to pull in.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 4:19-22; 7:10; 13:47-48; Mark 1:19-20; 6:41; Luke 5:1-7; John 21:1-14

Following Jesus

The Gospels are books about the life of Jesus. They help people understand and accept the invitation from Jesus to follow him. Jesus describes this as "taking up their cross." This invitation is not just for the closest followers of Jesus, called apostles. It is for everyone who wants to follow him (Mark 3:13-19; see also 1:16-20; 2:14; 8:34).

Some people find it very challenging to follow Jesus, but God offers help through his grace (Mark 10:17-25, 27). Others find it easy to respond to the invitation (Mark 2:14; see also Luke 7:36-50).

To "follow Jesus" means fully committing to leave behind selfish behaviors (Mark 8:34-35). "Taking up one's cross" means being willing to give up everything for Jesus, even one's life. For example, Peter, Andrew, James, and John left their homes and jobs to follow Jesus (Mark 1:16-20). A rich man had to sell everything and give the money to the poor to stop being selfish (Mark 10:21).

Following Jesus also involves publicly acknowledging him and being faithful to his teachings (Mark 8:38; compare Romans 10:9). It means removing anything that stops you from following Jesus, no matter how difficult (Mark 9:43–48). It involves trusting Jesus completely and refusing to sin (Mark 1:15; 6:12). It even requires being more loyal to Jesus than one's parents (Matt 10:37; Luke 14:26).

Jesus clearly told his disciples to share his message (Matthew 28:18–20; Luke 24:47–49; Acts 1:8). Throughout the New Testament, we see that the followers of Jesus told people about the good news wherever they went. This led many more people to become followers of Jesus (see Acts 2:14–41; 3:12–26; 4:1–2, 20; 8:4; 9:20; 11:19–26; 13:1–3; Romans 1:1–16; 10:14–15; 15:18–21; 1 Corinthians 9:16; Colossians 1:23; 1 Thessalonians 2:9; 2 Timothy 4:2).

Following Jesus brings both responsibilities and rewards. Those who follow him receive:

- a place in God's kingdom (Mark 9:43–48; 10:23–31),
- forgiveness for their sins (Mark 2:10–11; see also 3:28; 11:25),
- a place in God's family (John 1:12),
- protection from God's judgment (Mark 8:35; 13:13), and
- eternal life (Mark 9:43; 10:29–30; 1 John 5:11–12).

Passages for Further Study

Hosea 6:3; Matthew 10:37–39; 28:18–20; Mark 1:15–20; 2:14–15; 3:13–15; 5:18–20; 6:6–13, 30–32; 8:34–38; 9:38–50; 10:17–31; 11:22–25; 13:9–13; Luke 14:25–35; 24:47–49; John 8:12; 10:27; 12:26; Acts 1:8; 2:42–47; 4:16–20; 8:4; 9:19–30; 11:19–24; 13:1–3; Romans 1:1–16; 10:7–15; 1 Corinthians 9:16; Ephesians 5:1; Colossians 1:23; 2 Timothy 4:2; 1 Peter 2:21

Four World Empires

The book of Daniel describes two important visions that show how God rules over all of history. King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon had the first vision (chapter 2), and the prophet Daniel had a similar one (chapter 7). Each vision shows four world kingdoms.

People have sometimes disagreed about which kingdoms these visions described, but many important teachers throughout history have shared the same understanding. Hippolytus, an early Christian teacher (or “church father”) who lived from AD 170 to 236, identified the four kingdoms as:

- Babylonian,
- Media-Persia,
- Greece, and

- Rome.

Eusebius of Caesarea, another church father and historian who lived from AD 260 to 340, thought the first kingdom was Assyria (which had ruled over Babylon). However, he later agreed with Hippolytus's view. Most other early Christian teachers also accepted this understanding. Later, two other church fathers, Jerome and Augustine, agreed with this same explanation. Many Bible teachers today still accept this view of the four kingdoms.

In ancient times and today, some people have argued that Greece is the fourth empire. They consider Media and Persia as separate kingdoms. These teachers often believe this because they think the book of Daniel was written before the Roman Empire existed and could not have predicted future events. However, people usually consider Media and Persia to be one empire. By the time King Cyrus II conquered Babylon in 539 BC, the Persians had mostly combined the Median kingdom.

People generally consider Rome to be the fourth kingdom. But the evil and inhuman qualities described in the vision go beyond just the historical Roman Empire. The visions show a view of the world and its governments. The kingdom of God will destroy and replace all. It is “a stone ... cut out” (Daniel 2:34). In chapter 2, the statue's metals become less valuable. While in chapter 7, the animal imagery becomes more fierce and violent. These features show a decline in human civilization over time, even as the kingdom of God increases in power and size (2:35).

Passages for Further Study

Daniel 2:1–49; 7:1–28